

American Politics January 2026 General Exam

Instructions: Please answer 3 questions, making sure to answer at least one question from Part 1 and Part 2. Please read the questions carefully and make sure you answer all the parts of the questions you chose.

The exam is open book and open note. You are free to consult original source material, but not to consult another live person or to use LLMs/ChatGPT/etc.

Once you begin the exam, you have 8 hours to complete the exam.

Part 1.

1. Consider major theories of political parties and their positioning such as from Downs, Aldrich, Bawn et al. (2012, A Theory of Political Parties). Most such theories predate Donald Trump's nominations and victories in 2016 and 2024. To what extent is the positioning and electoral support for Donald Trump consistent or inconsistent with these major theories of political parties?
2. One canonical approach for measuring the quality of representation is to correlate roll call votes by members of Congress with average public opinion on the issue in the member's district as measured using survey data. A large positive correlation between, say, a constituency's support for free trade and their representative's vote for a free trade agreement, is interpreted as evidence for the quality of representation. Discuss the strengths and limitations of such an approach for assessing the nature of representation. A good answer will address how to interpret a correlation between average opinion and roll call voting, discuss any relevant measurement challenges, and propose potential improvements.
3. President Biden signed large subsidies to electric car manufacturers, but his re-election was opposed by the CEO of the country's largest electric car company; his advisors point to numerous policies that they say give him claim to being the "most pro-union President" in history, but in 2024 Democrats won one of the lowest shares of the union vote in decades. Do interest groups no longer matter in American politics? Do they matter in a different way than some scholars or practitioners think?
4. Does gender matter in American elections? If so, how? If not, why not? Address both voter behavior and candidate emergence.
5. For many years, political scientists were skeptical of the idea that campaign donations by the wealthy could buy policy, as exemplified by the 2003 article "Why is there so little money in American politics?". How well has that conventional wisdom held up in the wake of the changes in campaign finance law and practice? Evaluate the existing research and questions that remain to be answered.

Part 2.

1. Krehbiel (1993, 1998) asks “Where’s the Party?” while Cox and McCubbins (1993) argue parties are “legislative leviathans” in Congress. Explain the core theoretical disagreement between these theories of legislative organization. What observable implications distinguish these theories? Evaluate the empirical evidence, and assess what, if any, effects party leadership has in the legislative process.
2. Olson argued that concentrated interests have structural advantages in organizing and influencing policy, while diffuse interests face steep collective action problems. Yet history is full of examples where diffuse interests -- including parties, interest groups, and social movements -- have mobilized effectively. What conditions allow diffuse interests to overcome these challenges? Do such cases challenge Olson’s theory, or can they be reconciled with it?
3. Neustadt’s theory of presidential power emphasizes persuasion and bargaining as the foundations of presidential influence. Yet in recent decades, presidents have increasingly relied on unilateral action -- despite its political and legal risks. Do the number of unilateral executive orders capture influence? First, review the strongest arguments for and against the claim. Then, explain where you land on this debate.
4. Under what political conditions can bureaucratic agencies exercise significant influence over public policy? To what extent can Congress and the President enhance or erode the role of bureaucratic discretion in policy making?
5. Path dependence (Pierson 2000) and policy feedback (Pierson 1993) suggest that early political choices constrain later possibilities. Yet Patashnik (2008) shows that major reforms are often vulnerable to erosion. Reconcile these perspectives by explaining the conditions under which policies become self-reinforcing versus unstable. Use specific policy domains (welfare state, criminal justice, or another area) to illustrate your argument.